storeys high. They then covered the towers in fine white linen and decorated them with canopies of embroidered silk. Fa Xian tells us that the people placed idols of their gods within these structures and images of the Buddha on the corners of the wagons. On the day of the festival, twenty such wagons were pulled through the city in a grand procession. Devotees from all walks of life, ranging from the royal family to the poor, participated in the festivities. They offered prayers and flowers to the gods and lit lamps in the evening. The whole city became like a fair ground with amusements and games. We are also told that, on this day, the rich made generous donations to the poor and physicians even held free health clinics for them.

The festival described above is clearly the Rath Yatra or Chariot Festival that is still celebrated by Hindus in many parts of the country. The most famous is the one held in honour of Lord Jagannath in Puri, Orissa. From Fa Xian's description, the festival has survived almost unchanged since Gupta times. The only significant difference is that Buddhists used to actively participate in this event. Indeed, it appears that the popular practice of Buddhism and Hinduism overlapped significantly despite doctrinal disputes between scholars, and were seen to be part of the same spectrum. This relationship remains alive in the Indic family of religions. Nepali Hindus routinely worship at Buddhist shrines just as Buddhist Thais commonly pray to the Hindu god Brahma and Punjabi Hindus visit Sikh gurudwaras.

Not everything written in this period was about high literature, science or religion. One of the most famous books of this age is the *Kamasutra*, the Treatise on Love. It is best known for its long lists of complicated sexual positions, but it also tells us a lot about the social mores of that time. The book suggests that at least urban attitudes were surprisingly liberal. Although obviously written by a man, the *Kamasutra* is quite sensitive to the female perspective and even hints at a female readership. Most interestingly for our purposes, it paints a vivid picture of the life of a rich and idle *nagaraka* or 'a man-about-town'.[17]